SQUEEZE PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular squeeze play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

Having the defender's hands visible at the second page is not a perfect scenario. For example, there will be situations where you, as Declarer, are still playing for a suit to split 3-3 when you only have to peek at the hands to see that the split is 4-2. However, the other possibility of keeping the defender's hands hidden until later would prevent you from seeing how your plays are squeezing them. On balance, we decided to use the more open method.

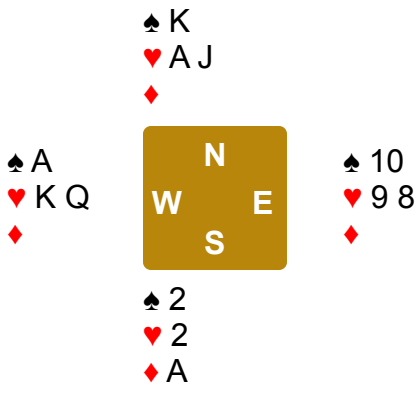
You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

You will notice that a large portion of the 20 Deals are slam hands. This is not because Squeezes don't arise in lower contracts, just that the presentation and explanations are less cluttered when there is only one (or none) trick that can be lost.

SQUEEZE PLAYS SUMMARY

The basic principle of a Squeeze Play can be summed up with this statement.

> A DEFENDER CANNOT HOLD ON TO THREE GUARD CARDS WHEN HE HAS ONLY TWO CARDS IN HIS HAND



South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

West cannot throw his ♠A because dummy's ♠K would then be high.

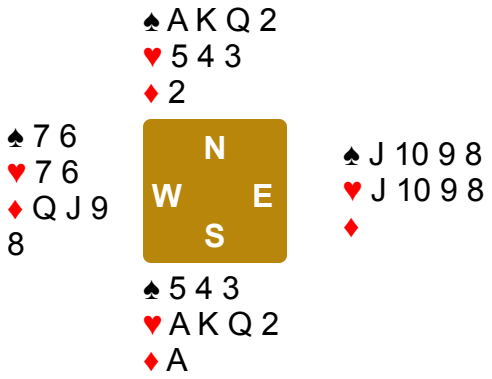
But he also cannot throw his ♥Q because then South would discard dummy's ♠K and win two tricks with ♥A, ♥J.

We say that West is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all three cards at a time when he had to come down to just two.

The statement in the blue box is definitely True, but it isn't complete.
You could also say:
A defender cannot hold four guards when he has only three cards.

Or even:
A defender cannot hold eight guards when he has only seven cards.

You get the idea. Look at an example of the eight and seven situation:



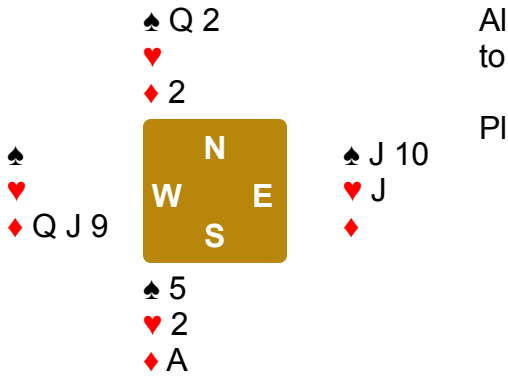
South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

East needs to keep all 4 ♠s to stop dummy's ♠2.

But he also must keep all 4 ♥s to stop your ♥2, (though he might not realize the importance of this).

We say that East is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all eight cards at a time when he had to come down to just seven.

Perhaps it is already obvious to you that all those extra winners in each hand don't affect the fundamental squeeze position. Take the last example and play dummy's ♠ A K and then your own ♥ A K Q. You would then have this basic position:



All the extra winners have already been won and you are down to basics.

Play the ♦A and squeeze East in ♠s and ♥s.

There are three terms we use when talking about squeezes.

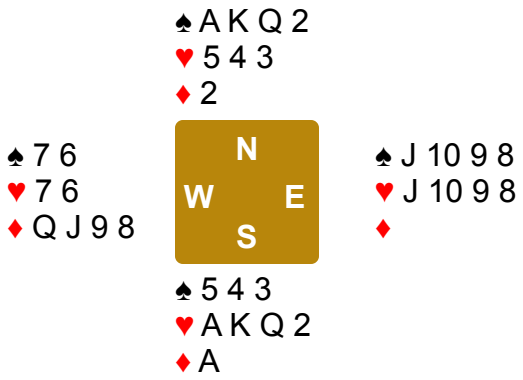
A **THREAT** is a card which is not yet a winner but THREATENS to become a winner if a defender discards a higher card in the suit. In the example above your ♥2 and dummy's ♠2 are both Threats.

A **GUARD** is a card(s) held by a defender that is preventing one of your Threats from becoming a winner. East's ♠ J 10 is a Guard against dummy's ♠2 and East's ♥J is a Guard against your ♥2.

The **SQUEEZE CARD** is the card you play which forces a defender to give up one of his Guards. Here the Squeeze Card was the ♦A.

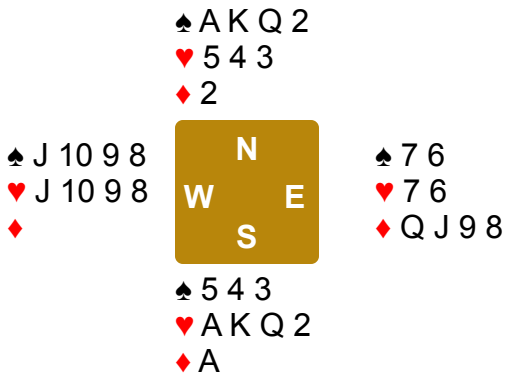
Automatic Squeeze:

Remember this?



South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:



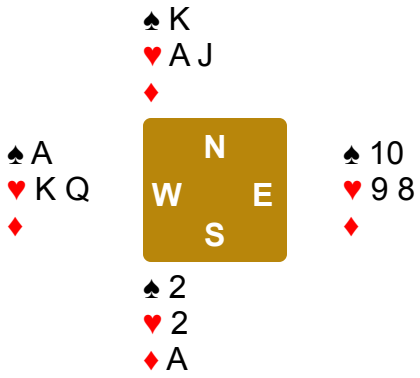
South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

An automatic squeeze is just a squeeze which will work equally well against either defender.

Deal 1 shows you a full example of an automatic squeeze. Feel free to go there right now and then come back for the next bit.

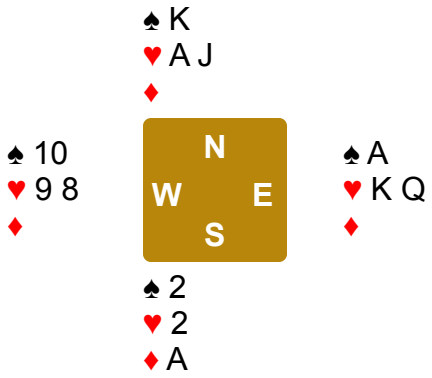
Positional Squeeze:

Remember this?



South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:



South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is not squeezed at all!
In fact it is dummy that is squeezed. Since dummy has to play before East does, East just watches and discards the same suit as dummy.

This is a Positional Squeeze, so called because it only works on one of the Defenders.

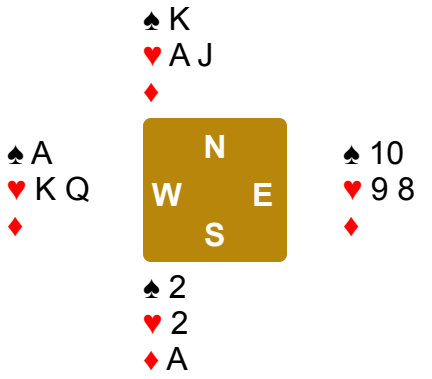
Deal 2 is an example of a positional squeeze. Feel free to go check it out, then come back.

Rectifying the Count:

That may sound rather high-tech but it's not really that bad.

MOST SQUEEZES CAN ONLY OCCUR WHEN
YOU MUST WIN ALL THE REST OF THE TRICKS

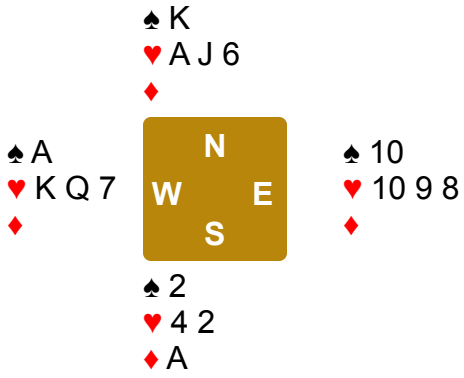
Look at this end position one more time.



South needs to win all the rest of the tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.
He is squeezed because all of his cards are Busy - they are all doing guardwork.

Now give everybody an extra ♥.



South needs to win 3 of the last 4 tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is not squeezed.
He has one card, the ♥7, which is not Busy doing guardwork.
So he just discards that card and awaits his two tricks.

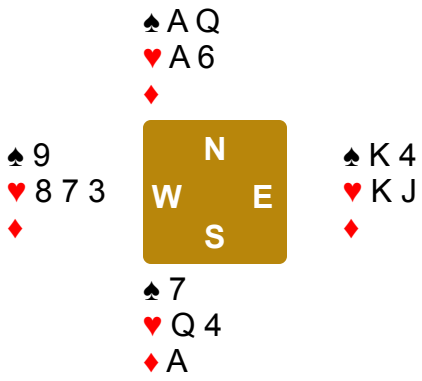
If you checked out Deals 1 and 2 earlier you didn't run across this problem. And for a very good reason - both of those Deals involved Grand Slams so you were already in a spot where you needed the "rest of the tricks".

When you are playing a small slam, though, rectifying the count is vital. So when your Plan calls for a squeeze to be made at the end you will have to give up one trick to the defenders early.

Deal 3 (surprise) just happens to demonstrate rectifying the count. So if you want to see it work in the context of a full deal just check that out and then come back when you are done.

The Vienna Coup:

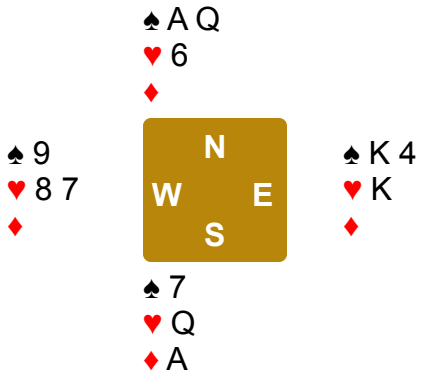
Nice name, huh?
Take a look at this ending, where South needs to win all four tricks. South is in her hand and can certainly win the three Aces. She has two Threats, the ♠Q and the ♥Q with which she hope to squeeze East.



South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East will throw his ♥J because he can see that he must hold onto both ♠s.
Dummy's ♥A now drops the ♥K, and establishes South's ♥Q.
BUT SHE HAS NO ENTRY TO IT, SHE IS LOCKED IN DUMMY.

So, let us apply the Vienna Coup! At some earlier time, perhaps the first trick, or the fourth trick or whenever, dummy's ♥A was played. So the ending would now look like this:



South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East is squeezed in ♥s and ♠s.
The difference here is that South no longer needs an extra entry to her ♥Q because she is already in her hand.

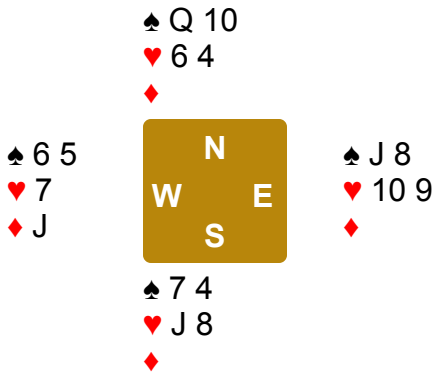
THE VIENNA COUP IS THE CASHING OF A HIGH CARD IN ONE HAND TO CREATE A THREAT IN THE OTHER HAND

Want to see the Vienna Coup in action?
Go to Deal 7, then come on back.

The Suicide Squeeze: (aka the Cannibal Squeeze)

This squeeze often occurs when the defenders have made a mistake, but there are some situations where they defend perfectly and still get caught in it. What happens is that one defender cashes a winner and in so doing squeezes his partner.

Look at this ending:



West cashes the ♦J.

Discard the ♥4 from dummy and the ♠4 from your hand. East is squeezed and you win the last three tricks.

If West had just ignored the ♦ winner and led one of the other suits East would have been assured of taking 2 tricks.

There is just one Suicide Squeeze Deal presented in this set so I won't identify it for you, just be on the lookout.

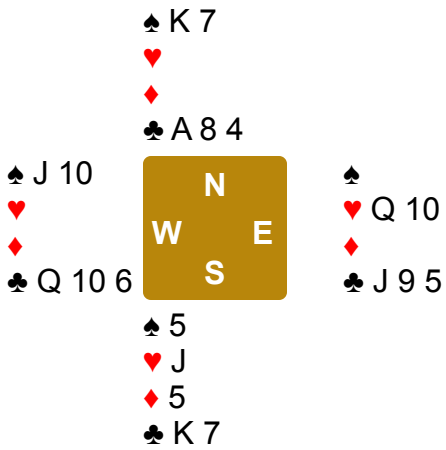
The Double Squeeze:

Usually you think of a squeeze occuring when one defender is trying to guard two suits. In these descriptions we have often said "East is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s." But sometimes when you are trying to set up a squeeze on one player it will turn out that West guards one suit but East guards the other suit. So you try to get a situation where neither one can guard a THIRD suit.

That sounds messier than it should. Suppose you have a long ♦ suit which you play to use for a squeeze. It turns out that West guards a ♠ threat while East guards a ♥ threat.

You will say to yourself: "West guards the spades, East guards the hearts, nobody can guard the clubs."

Here is how it works:



You play your ♦5.

West is not squeezed, but he must keep both ♠s to guard against dummy so he is forced to discard a ♣. Since you know your ♠7 cannot win a trick now you throw it. East is not squeezed, he can spare the ♥10.

But you then play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K. This squeezes East who now has the sole guard for both ♥s and ♣s. He will probably throw his ♣5 in which case you take the last 3 ♣ tricks.

Deal 13 is a good example of a Double Squeeze.

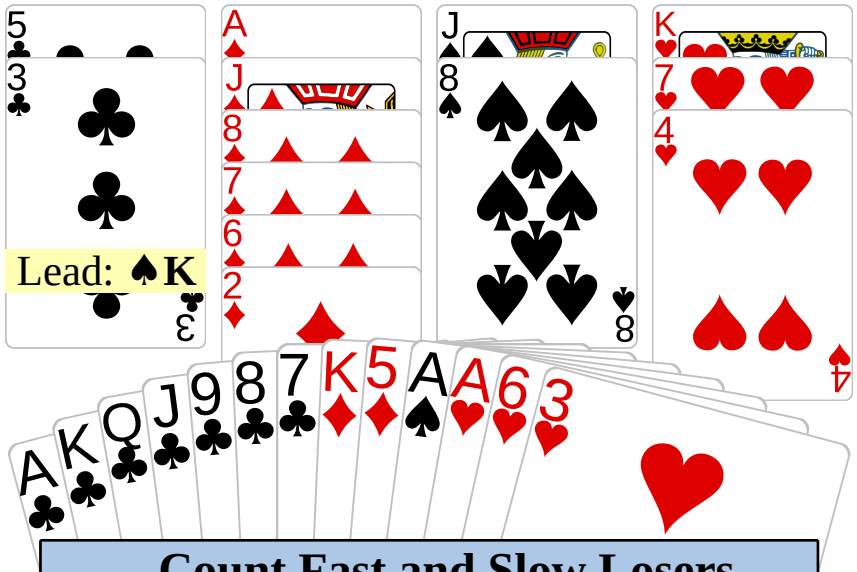
That's all folks:

I didn't start this lesson by talking about how difficult Squeeze Plays are. As you have seen, though, they do require some effort, both learning how to execute them and in the execution itself. Most of the examples here are classified as Simple Squeezes. There is another whole level.

If your interest is piqued you might want to look for the Vise Squeeze, or perhaps the Winkle and the Stepping-Stone squeeze. How about the Trump Squeeze or the Criss-cross squeeze?

Good luck.

Deal 1 Ctr: **7♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



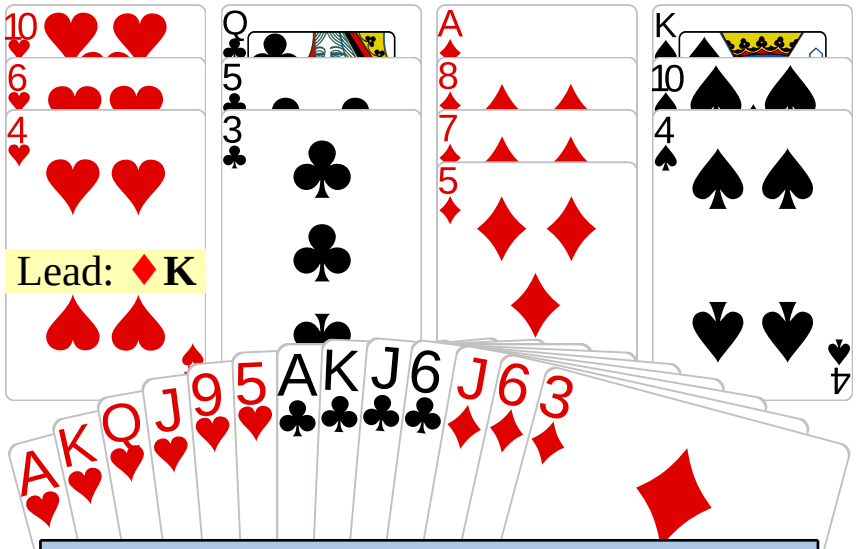
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



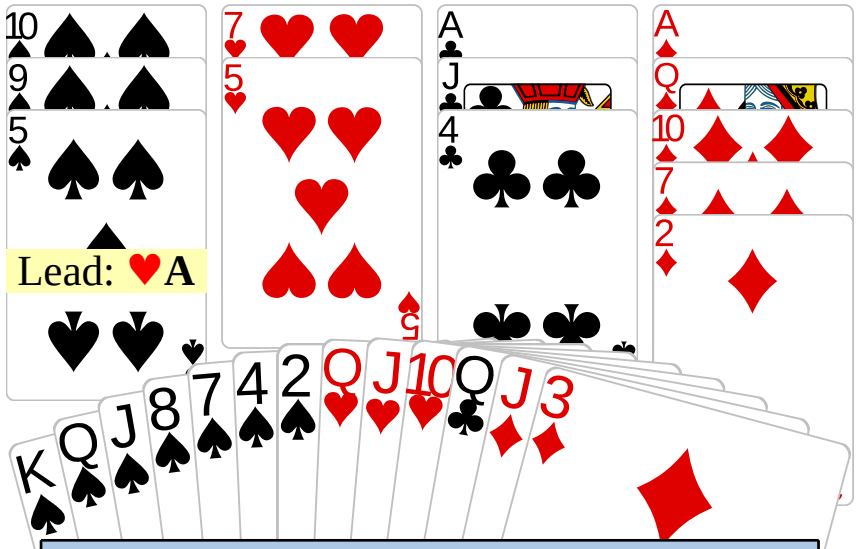
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 7♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠A

Board: 3
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦K

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥A

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A ♥ A 6 3 ♦ K 5 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7	
♠ 10 7 5 4 2 ♥ J 10 2 ♦ Q 10 4 3 ♣ 4		♠ K Q 9 6 3 ♥ Q 9 8 5 ♦ 9 ♣ 10 6 2
	♠ J 8 ♥ K 7 4 ♦ A J 8 7 6 2 ♣ 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]
Pass	5NT[3]	Pass	6♦[4]
Pass	7♣		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace
3. asks for kings
4. 1 king

7♣ by North
Lead: ♠K

North is to play 7♣. East leads the ♠K.

At first glance this doesn't appear to be a difficult hand. You expect to win the opening lead, pull trumps, then establish a ♦ winner by playing ♦K, ♦A, and ruffing a ♦. As long as they split 3-2 you could reach dummy's ♦ winner with the ♥K.

So you take the ♠A, pull three rounds of trumps and play ♦K.

But when you lead to the ♦A East discards a small ♠.

Time to rethink. You are in dummy now, and you can ruff a ♦, return with the ♥K and ruff another ♦. The last ♦ would be good but you'd have no way to reach it.

Think squeeze instead.

You ruff a ♦. This turns the ♦J into a Threat card against West's ♦Q.

But, the ♠J is already a Threat card against East's ♠Q.

You play your ♣J.

Play your ♣J and ♣9, discarding the ♦8 and the ♥4 from dummy.

East can afford to discard the ♠9 and the ♥5.

West can spare his two ♠s.

You are there.

East gives up the ♥8.

Your ♣8 does it.

East cannot throw the ♠Q, so he gives up the ♥8. Dummy's ♠J is of no further value so you dump it.

West cannot throw the ♦Q, so he gives up the ♥2.

And you take the last three tricks with the ♥ suit. There were only two defenders; one of them had to guard ♠s and the other had to guard ♦s. There was nobody left to guard ♥s.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 10 9 7 ♥ 4 ♦ Q J 9 4 2 ♣ J 10 9 3	
♠ Q 4 ♥ J 9 7 3 ♦ K 7 5 ♣ 8 6 5 2	N W E S	♠ — ♥ A K Q 10 5 ♦ A 8 6 3 ♣ A K Q 4
	♠ A K J 8 6 5 3 2 ♥ 8 6 2 ♦ 10 ♣ 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♣	4♠
Pass	Pass	5♥	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠A

East is to play 6♥. South leads the ♠A.

If ♦s and ♣s split nicely this would be an easy slam. But with that wild ♠ bid by South you can't expect decent splits.

So you ruff the ♠, pull trumps in three rounds, then play ♣ A K and get the bad news when South discards a ♠.

You now know that North guards the ♣s. And since South had 3 ♥s and a very long ♠ suit it is pretty likely that North guards the ♦s also. You will try to squeeze North in ♣s and ♦s, but first you must lose a trick to rectify the count.

South plays the ♦10.

So you play a low ♦ from each hand.

It doesn't matter which defender takes the ♦, since either one is going to do the same thing. Assume South wins the ♦10.

He will then play the ♠K, which you must ruff in your hand.

South discards.

A small ♦ to dummy's ♦K.

You are in dummy, ready for the squeeze.

You play dummy's ♥J.

North gets to choose his own fate - discarding a protector in one of the two suits. Of course, whichever suit he discards you will throw the opposite one.

Yet another slam, courtesy of the Squeeze Play!

Board 3
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 10 4 ♥ 10 6 4 ♦ A 8 7 5 ♣ Q 5 3	
♠ A Q 9 7 6 3 ♥ 3 ♦ K Q 10 2 ♣ 9 7	N W E S	♠ J 8 5 2 ♥ 8 7 2 ♦ 9 4 ♣ 10 8 4 2
	♠ — ♥ A K Q J 9 5 ♦ J 6 3 ♣ A K J 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♠	Pass	Pass	Dbl
2♦	2NT	Pass	4♥
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

6♥ by South
Lead: ♦K

South is to play 6♥. West leads the ♦K. Perhaps you wouldn't have bid slam with North's cards, but he has been watching you pull off some fantastic squeeze plays and he has every confidence you will do it again.

You know West also has the ♦Q, so your ♦J will be a Threat card against him.

And you are 99.9% sure he also has the ♠A, so dummy's ♠K will also be a Threat card against him.

You should be able to squeeze him in the two suits. What is your first act?

Your first act should be to rectify the count. And the safest way to do that is to just let West hold the first trick. Who knows, he might be foolish enough to play another ♦, or even to lead the ♠A. Defenders do make mistakes sometimes.

But not this defender, not this time.

He exits with the ♥3 which you take with your ♥Q.

Pull two more rounds of trumps, then run four ♣s, ending in your hand.

You throw a ♠ from dummy and West discards ♠s and ♦s.

You are closing in. Play the ♥J, then the ♥9.

Discard the ♠10 and ♦7 from dummy.

West discards the ♠Q and ♠9.

West bares his ♦Q.

At last you play the ♥5, and West is done, he just doesn't know it yet.

He obviously is not going to throw his ♠A and make dummy high, so he will instead bare his ♦Q.

So you dump dummy's ♠K and win the last two tricks with the ♦A and then the ♦J.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 6 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ 6 5 4 ♣ 9 8 7 5 3 2	
♠ K Q J 8 7 4 2 ♥ Q J 10 ♦ J 3 ♣ Q	N W E S	♠ 10 9 5 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A Q 10 7 2 ♣ A J 4
	♠ A 3 ♥ K 9 8 4 2 ♦ K 9 8 ♣ K 10 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
1♠	Pass	2♥	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♥A

East's 2♥ cue-bid shows ♠ support and at least a limit-raise or better. West is to play 4♠. North leads the ♥A, then a ♥ to South's ♥K. South plays a third round of ♥s.

You were expecting to see all four hands, not just East/West again. The reason you are seeing it like this is that you must do some deducing first.

You saw the bidding and you know that North started with the ♥A and South started with the ♥K.

Before you can make a good Plan you need to figure out where the ♠A, ♦K and ♣K are located.

The three unaccounted for honors have a value of 10 points and every one of them must be in South's hand. With the ♥K he still needs those points to have enough strength to open the bidding. So you can forget about either finesse working.

Now on with the plan. South/North took the first two ♥ tricks and then played a third ♥ which you won, discarding the ♦2 from dummy.

You need to pull trumps so you play your ♠K. South wins with his ♠A and returns the ♠3 to your ♠Q.**

This pulls all the trumps and also serves to rectify the count for your upcoming squeeze.

**By the way, notice that if South had played any other way he would have handed you the contract.

You plan to squeeze South in ♦s and ♣s. But if you start running your trumps now you will have a problem with dummy's discards. You will come down to the ♦ A Q and the ♣ A J and will have to discard one of them BEFORE South has to discard.

So dummy's ♦Q cannot be one of the Threat cards. Instead you must make the ♦J in YOUR hand a Threat.

North plays low.

You play the ♦A immediately, a Vienna Coup.

Now that you have your Threats properly positioned you can get on with the squeeze.

Overtake dummy's ♠10 and run three more ♠s.

Discard all three ♦s from dummy.

South will discard his 2 ♥s, the ♦9 and the ♣6.

And now the moment you have been waiting for all these 20 Deals.

North discards.

Play your ♠2 and discard dummy's ♣4.